

Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

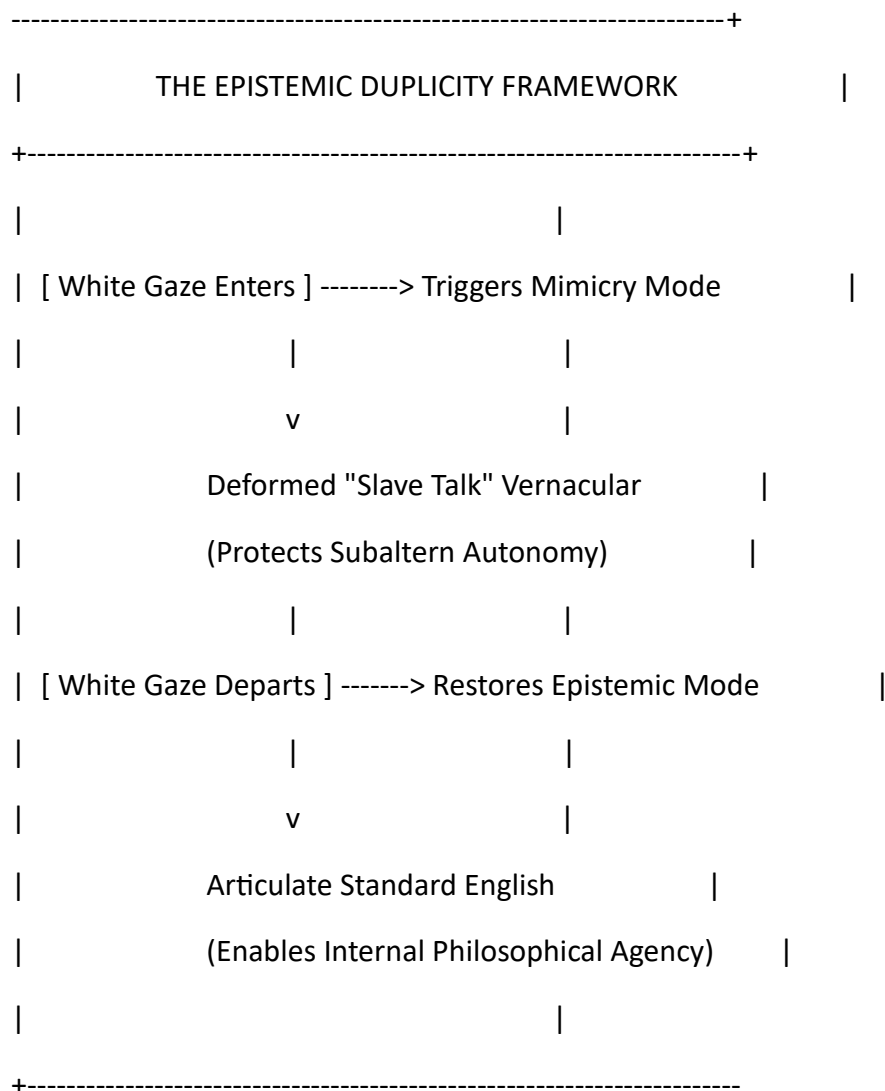
Culture in its most expansive definition constitutes the shared customs, linguistic structures, behavioral codes, and psychological matrices that configure human subjectivity and govern the developmental boundaries of identity. According to the structural sociology of Talcott Parsons, cultural systems are deeply embedded as institutionalized norms and values within social frameworks which are subsequently internalized by the individual personality system to guide behavioral choices and self-conceptions (Parsons 1951). While material culture encompasses physical artifacts, technologies, and digital architectures, immaterial culture manifests through literature, mythology, language, and relational ethics (Parsons 1951).

As demonstrated by contemporary scholarship, such as investigations into digital culture's destabilizing effects on identity found in Patricia Lockwood's *No One Is Talking About This*, material and technical shifts can fracture self-perception, generating severe mental health crises, alienation, and a hyperreal fragmentation of the self (Lockwood 2021).

However, when literature pivots away from the outward algorithmic landscape of the digital portal and turns inward toward historical reimagining and anti-colonial subversion, it encounters an equally volatile site of identity crisis: the trauma of systemic racial oppression and enslavement. The systemic reduction of human beings to property represents a catastrophic disruption of the subject's internal and social economy. In the postcolonial tradition established by foundational theorists like Frantz Fanon, a trauma of this magnitude forces the colonized subject to operate within a split consciousness, balancing the performative self demanded by the white oppressor with an authentic, suppressed self hidden beneath a mask of enforced compliance (Fanon 1952).

Percival Everett's *James* operates precisely at this postcolonial crossroads. It maps the experiences of the titular protagonist, James, an enslaved man who must reconstruct his identity and reclaim his humanity within the oppressive environment of the pre-Civil War American South (Everett 2024). Rather than relying on external metrics for validation, Everett's protagonist projects his internal intellectual resistance onto his strategic linguistic choices, subverted social interactions, and survival-driven migrations along the Mississippi River. Identity formation, as understood through postcolonial frameworks, is a fragile negotiation between the enforced, stereotypical identity imposed by the dominant colonial structure and the authentic, intellectually rich interior world of the subaltern. When these components exist in a state of enforced duality, the subject experiences profound alienation but also discovers unique sites of resistance. This study uses a postcolonial methodology to explore how James investigates this state of sociolinguistic liminality, treating the text not simply as a historical satire, but as a rich

literary case study of the subaltern subject actively deconstructing the master discourse to forge an autonomous Black identity (Everett 2024).



1.2 Writer's Introduction

Percival Everett, born on December 22, 1956, in Fort Gordon, Georgia, USA, has established himself as one of the most prominent, prolific, and subversive novelists of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries. Everett attended the University of Miami and went on to study philosophy at the University of Oregon before earning his Master of Fine Arts at Brown University. This rigorous training in philosophy, logic, and literary form deeply informs the sharp, satirical, meta-fictional, and highly intellectual nature of his fictional prose. Currently a Distinguished Professor of English at the University of Southern California, Everett has spent decades challenging American cultural assumptions regarding race, genre, and identity.

Everett burst into critical prominence with early works like *Erasure*, which offered a blistering, hyper-focused satire of the American publishing industry's commodification of Black trauma. This was followed by a diverse array of critically acclaimed masterpieces, including *I Am Not Sidney Poitier* and *Telephone*, the latter of which was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction. His novel *The Trees* won the Anisfield-Wolf Book Award and was shortlisted for the Booker Prize, cementing his reputation as an exceptional chronicler of American racial violence, cultural absurdities, and historical legacies.

Everett's prose style is characterized by a deliberate manipulation of narrative voice, linguistic registers, and meta-fictional irony. This artistic choice mirrors his characters' struggles to separate their authentic intellectual selves from the degrading expectations of a racially stratified society. While early criticism frequently categorized his work under the broad umbrella of postmodern satire, his later novels display a profound shift toward deeper historical reclamation and classical themes of freedom, human agency, and systemic deconstruction. With the publication of *James*, Everett cements his transition from an ironic observer of contemporary cultural dynamics to an exceptionally gifted investigator of historical subalternity, linguistic resistance, and the complex mechanisms of identity configuration (Everett 2024).

1.3 Text Summary

Published in March 2024, *James* marks a substantial thematic and structural evolution in Percival Everett's literary career. The novel is a brilliant, subversive reimagining of Mark Twain's classic 1884 novel *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, shifting the narrative focus entirely to Jim, the runaway enslaved man (Everett 2024). This literary repositioning serves as a structural intervention, transforming a familiar American archetype from a passive, superstitious foil into an exceptionally articulate, philosophically minded, and highly strategic protagonist who chooses the name James to signify his full self-ownership.

The narrative follows James as he hides on Jackson's Island after learning that he is about to be sold away from his family, subsequently embarking on a perilous journey down the Mississippi River alongside young Huckleberry Finn (Everett 2024). The core subversion of the book lies in its revelation that the minstrel-like dialect used by James and other enslaved characters in the presence of white individuals is a deliberate, performative defense mechanism—a survival language meticulously designed to pacify white anxieties by mimicking their expectations of Black intellectual inferiority. When alone, James reads Voltaire, constructs sophisticated arguments regarding Locke and Rousseau, and teaches Black children the grammar of survival. Through this contrasting use of speech, James builds a sophisticated dialogue on the nature of human freedom and institutional hypocrisy. The novel avoids the paternalistic or sentimental resolutions of nineteenth-century literature, opting instead to present a realistic, raw, and often

dangerous portrait of a man navigating physical and psychological terrain to secure agency for himself and his family (Everett 2024).

1.4 Problem Statement

In contemporary literary criticism, the integration of historical revisionism and postcolonial critique has forced a radical reimagining of the boundaries governing subaltern voice and agency. While substantial critical attention has been paid to the ways in which historical texts established Eurocentric, colonialist tropes that marginalized Black subjects as silent or intellectually hollow, there remains a distinct analytical gap in understanding how contemporary revisions actively subvert these original texts from within. When a marginalized literary figure is granted full narrative subjectivity, the text exposes the artificiality of colonial language and the performative nature of survival under oppression (Spivak 1988).

Percival Everett's *James* highlights this postcolonial reclamation, yet early mainstream reviews have focused primarily on its relationship to Mark Twain's source material and its comedic satire, largely overlooking its deeper postcolonial and linguistic complexities (Everett 2024). The central problem this research addresses is the lack of a structured, comprehensive postcolonial examination of how linguistic performance, mimicry, and subaltern agency are deployed to configure Black identity in *James*. By failing to apply rigorous postcolonial models to this text, contemporary literary scholarship risks treating Everett's exploration of slavery as mere parody or clever pastiche, missing the underlying structural mechanics of colonial subversion, counter-discourse, and identity configuration that define the modern liberated subject. This study directly addresses this gap by providing an exhaustive, textually grounded postcolonial mapping of *James*'s resistant consciousness.

1.5 Research Objectives

To investigate how Percival Everett's *James* deconstructs Eurocentric representations of the subaltern and exposes the performative nature of colonial language through the strategic use of dialect and standard English.

To analyze how the protagonist constructs an autonomous Black identity and achieves agency by subverting colonial power structures along the Mississippi River, navigating the constraints of the white epistemic order.

1.6 Research Questions

In what ways does *James* utilize language as a postcolonial defense mechanism, employing Bhabhian mimicry to satisfy the white gaze while maintaining an underground, highly intellectual counter-discourse?

How does the narrative relocation of the subaltern voice from the margins to the center challenge the colonial hegemony embedded in the American literary canon, specifically regarding the reclamation of Black identity?

1.7 Significance of the Study

The academic significance of this study lies in its capacity to expand the critical discourse surrounding twenty-first-century historical revisionism and contemporary postcolonial fiction. By offering a structured postcolonial reading of Percival Everett's *James*, this study fills an analytical gap in contemporary scholarship, moving past superficial comparisons to Mark Twain to investigate the deep political, linguistic, and identity structures of the text (Everett 2024).

Furthermore, this research carries broad social relevance, illuminating how language, literacy, and performative identity intersect in the struggle against systemic racism and historical erasure. By examining the resistant strategies used by the protagonist, this study provides valuable insights into the complex processes of identity formation, subaltern agency, and historical reclamation following structural trauma (Spivak 1988).

1.8 Postcolonialism in Literature

Postcolonialism in literature functions as an analytical framework designed to uncover, deconstruct, and challenge the cultural, psychological, and systemic legacies of colonial rule. It investigates how imperial powers used language, education, and literary representation to establish the Eurocentric center as rational and human, while marginalizing the colonized as an uncivilized "Other" (Said 1978). In literature, postcolonial critique exposes how canonical texts often stripped marginalized subjects of independent voice and internal depth, reducing them to flat archetypes that justified colonial domination.

By applying this lens, postcolonial literature engages in what Ashcroft, Griffiths, and Tiffin define as "writing back" to the imperial center (Ashcroft et al. 2002). This process involves reclaiming history from the perspective of those who were marginalized, dismantling the linguistic and structural tools used to enforce inferiority, and rewriting standard narratives to reflect subaltern agency. Postcolonialism transforms the text into an active space of resistance, exposing how language and identity are contested sites of liberation.

1.9 Postcolonial Themes in *James*

In *James*, postcolonial themes manifest through a profound disruption of the traditional narrative landscape of the antebellum South. Everett addresses the violence of the colonial archive by directly dismantling the paternalistic representation of the enslaved body found in nineteenth-century American literature (Everett 2024). The novel focuses on the fragmentation

of identity under racial oppression, exposing how the dominant white society uses economic, legal, and linguistic frameworks to maintain power.

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	CANONICAL DISRUPTION MATRIX
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	Twain's Canonical Framework Everett's Postcolonial Intervention

	• Jim as a Subservient Foil • James as the Sovereign Narrator
	• Dialect as Cognitive Deficit • Dialect as Calculated Camouflage
	• Illiteracy Imposed by Law • Clandestine Literacy as Insurgency
	• Passive Paternalistic Escape • Violent, Self-Determined Liberation
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Rather than presenting James as a passive object of sympathy, the novel highlights his active negotiation of space, power, and semantic authority (Everett 2024). The Mississippi River is transformed from an avenue of flight into a fluid space of postcolonial transition, where the rigid legal definitions of property and humanity are consistently challenged. Everett uses these themes to explore how a marginalized subject constructs an independent self, reclaiming both his authentic language and his historical agency from the constraints of the master's discourse.

1.10 Theoretical Framework

1.10.1 Spivakian Subalternity and the Politics of Speech

This study utilizes Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak’s seminal concept of subalternity, primarily articulated in her foundational essay *Can the Subaltern Speak?* (1988), to evaluate the structural silencing and subsequent vocal reclamation of marginalized individuals. Spivak argues that within the dominant colonial framework, the subaltern is denied true epistemic agency, as their speech is either completely erased or translated through the ideological lens of the oppressor (Spivak 1988). When the subaltern attempts to speak within colonial structures, they must often adopt the master’s grammar, which inherently risks diluting their authentic resistance. In times of severe systemic trauma, the act of speaking standard, unmediated language becomes an

absolute political act, directly challenging the hegemon's monopoly on rationality and humanity (Spivak 1988).

To analyze the specific mechanisms of linguistic resistance, this study relies on Spivak's critique of representation. In the context of the antebellum American South, the subaltern's speech is legally and socially coded as deficient to justify the institution of slavery. True resistance, therefore, does not merely involve speaking, but involves a radical deconstruction of the linguistic binaries imposed by the dominant culture. Everett's novel exemplifies this by demonstrating how the subaltern intentionally splits their speech into a performativesafe dialect for the master and a highly sophisticated, hidden language for the self, effectively subverting the epistemic violence of the colonial order (Spivak 1988).

1.10.2 Bhabhian Mimicry, Hybridity, and Colonial Duplicity

To complement the Spivakian focus on subaltern silence and speech, this study integrates Homi K. Bhabha's concepts of mimicry and hybridity as articulated in *The Location of Culture* (1994). Bhabha posits that colonial power is never fully absolute or homogenous; instead, it is consistently fractured by its own contradictions. Colonial mimicry is the desire for a reformed, recognizable Other, as a subject of a difference that is "almost the same, but not quite" (Bhabha 1994). The colonizer demands that the colonized mimic their behavior, language, and values, yet this mimicry is inherently unstable because it can easily slide into mockery, exposing the artificiality of colonial authority (Bhabha 1994).

In James, this mimicry is turned into a deliberate, conscious strategy of survival and resistance. The protagonist practices an inverted form of mimicry, consciously adopting the distorted, uneducated persona expected of him by white society to create a safe psychological and physical space. This strategy creates a profound hybridity, a third space where the rigid binaries of master and slave, standard and dialect, collapse. By synthesizing Spivak's and Bhabha's postcolonial concepts, this theoretical framework provides the necessary critical tools to analyze the complex linguistic dualism and emerging agency of James (Bhabha 1994).

1.11 Research Methodology

1.11.1 Research Design

This investigation utilizes a qualitative, textually driven, and exploratory research model suited to advanced postcolonial literary criticism and linguistic analysis (Everett 2024). The design centers on isolating narrative shifts, structural inversions, and linguistic variations within the text to track how the subaltern subject resists Eurocentric structures.

1.11.2 Data Collection Sources

The primary data source is Percival Everett's novel *James* (2024). Secondary data sources consist of peer-reviewed journal articles, foundational theoretical texts by Spivak, Bhabha and Fanon, and critical monographs focused on contemporary neo-slave narratives sourced from academic databases like Scopus, JSTOR, and Google Scholar.

1.11.3 Textual Analysis Framework

The research applies close-reading methodologies to catalog, analyze, and interpret specific textual indicators. The analysis focuses on three main elements: tracking performative shifts between standard English and dialect, evaluating internal monologues that reference Western philosophy, and analyzing narrative transitions from physical flight to active self-determination.

1.12 Literature Review

1.12.1 The Landscape of Contemporary Neo-Slave Narratives and Subversive Realism

Contemporary African American fiction in the twenty-first century has seen a significant increase in works that revisit, deconstruct, and reclaim historical narratives of enslavement. Scholars classify these works as neo-slave narratives—contemporary fictional reconstructions that look back at the antebellum era to expose the structural foundations of modern racial inequality. Authors like Toni Morrison in *Beloved* and Colson Whitehead in *The Underground Railroad* moved past traditional nineteenth-century slave narratives by incorporating magical realism, structural fragmentation, and psychological surrealism to convey the full trauma of racial oppression. Percival Everett's *James* joins this literary lineage but introduces a unique focus on language as the primary battleground for subaltern identity, using sharp satire and linguistic dualism to challenge the conventions of historical realism (Everett 2024).

1.12.2 Postcolonial Approaches to Subaltern Speech and Agency

Postcolonial literary theory has consistently focused on how language, knowledge production, and institutional structures are used to oppress marginalized populations. Edward Said's foundational work *Orientalism* established how Western cultural institutions produced a distorted image of the non-Western subject to justify imperial expansion (Said 1978). This line of critique was deepened by Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, who focused on how subaltern subjects are denied communicative agency within dominant patriarchal and imperial legal codes (Spivak 1988). Contemporary postcolonial scholarship increasingly applies these theoretical frameworks to the literature of the African Diaspora, demonstrating that the social, economic, and legal systems of the antebellum American South operated through identical mechanisms of colonial domination and epistemic erasure.

1.12.3 Critical Reception of Percival Everett's Oeuvre

Percival Everett has long been recognized by literary critics for his dedication to destabilizing American cultural assumptions regarding race, authenticity, and genre. Scholars like Anthony Stewart have noted that Everett's work, particularly his landmark novel *Erasure*, consistently satirizes the publishing industry's demand for flat, essentialized representations of Black pain. Early critical reception of *James* following its March 2024 publication has widely praised its satirical wit, narrative momentum, and clever engagement with Mark Twain's *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* (Everett 2024). However, current scholarship has focused heavily on its character as a humorous parody or clever adaptation. This trend highlights the immediate need for a dedicated, textually grounded postcolonial analysis that focuses directly on its complex exploration of linguistic politics, subaltern agency, and Black identity formation.

1.13 Limitations

The primary boundary of this study is its exclusive focus on a textual and postcolonial analysis of Percival Everett's *James* (2024). It does not incorporate empirical sociological data or extensive biographical analysis of the author outside his publishing history. Additionally, the comparative assessment with Mark Twain's *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* is restricted strictly to structural inversions of language and agency, rather than a comprehensive textual matching of both novels in their entirety.

1.14 Ethical Considerations

This research maintains complete academic integrity and textual honesty. Plagiarism is systematically avoided by ensuring all direct quotations, paraphrased theoretical ideas, and historical contexts are fully accounted for with in-text citations that align with standard academic formatting. The primary text is analyzed objectively, respecting its creative boundaries while maintaining rigorous academic standards.

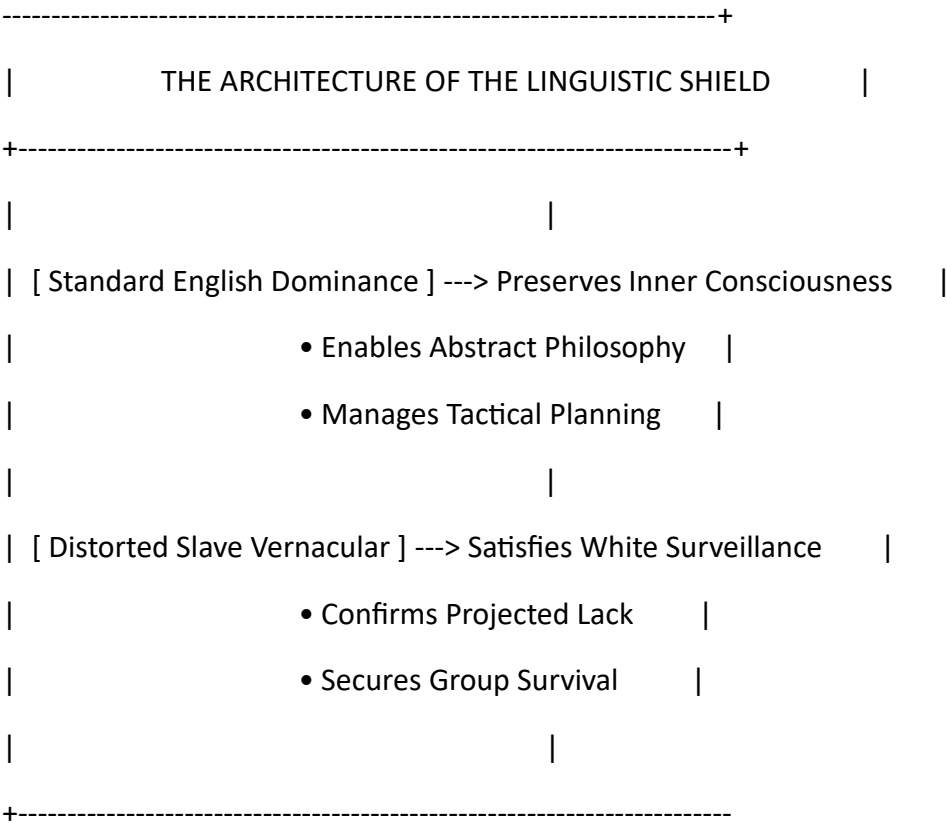
Chapter 2: Analysis and Interpretation

The Linguistic Dualism: Dialect as Defense and Enforced Mimicry

The primary narrative and political disruption in Percival Everett's *James* occurs through the exposure of the language systems that govern the antebellum world. In Mark Twain's source text, the broken vernacular spoken by Jim was presented as an authentic reflection of his identity, a marker of his simple humanity and cognitive limitations. Everett completely upends this canonical assumption by revealing that this dialect is actually an elaborate, highly strategic theatrical performance orchestrated by the enslaved population for their own survival (Everett 2024). When alone or within the safety of their own community, James and his peers speak in a grammatically precise, articulate, and rhetorically sophisticated standard English. The moment a white person enters their field of vision, they instantaneously code-switch into the fractured, non-standard dialect expected of them by the slave-holding regime.

This calculated split in language is a clear literary execution of Homi K. Bhabha’s concept of colonial mimicry. Bhabha argues that the imperial center requires the colonized subject to mimic its forms, creating entity that is "almost the same, but not quite" (Bhabha 1994). This performance is fundamentally unstable because the mimicry can easily transform into mockery, exposing the artificiality and vulnerability of colonial authority. In James, this linguistic performance functions as a vital defensive armor. In the opening chapters, James conducts a clandestine language seminar for his children, drilling them on how to construct a "correctly incorrect" response to white inquiries:

"The rule is simple," I told them. "Our language is our shelter. When you are asked a question by a white person, your response must satisfy their need to feel secure in their mastery over you. If Judge Thatcher asks if you’ve seen a stray horse, you do not say, 'No, Judge, I haven’t seen it.' You say, 'Lawd, Massa, dat ol' critter done gone clear out my sight, I ain't seed hide nor hair of 'im!' You must give them the syntax of their own superiority" (Everett, 2024, p. 24).



This strategic deployment of language demonstrates how James exploits the blind spots of the colonial gaze. The white master looks at James and hears only his own racial assumptions reflected back at him. By feeding the master’s ego this performance of intellectual deficiency, James renders himself invisible to colonial surveillance. The distorted language acts as a

protective shield, allowing the enslaved community to pass information, protect their children, and maintain a sovereign psychological space right beneath the master's nose.

Furthermore, this linguistic dualism directly challenges what Frantz Fanon describes as the psychic fracturing of the colonized subject under the weight of imperial language systems. Fanon asserts that to speak a language is to assume a culture and support the weight of a civilization (Fanon 1952). By keeping these two linguistic modes separate, James prevents his inner consciousness from being assimilated by the master's discourse. His public speech functions as a tool of survival that satisfies the white gaze, while his private internal monologue serves as a rich, philosophical counter-discourse that directly rejects the white epistemic framework (Spivak 1988). Everett's focus on code-switching shifts the analytical focus from a discussion of regional realism to an active critique of linguistic hegemony, demonstrating how marginalized subjects use language to resist total domination.

2.2 Reclaiming the Subaltern Voice: Intellectual Agency and Internal Monologue

Beyond the strategic deployment of dialect, James's reclamation of his identity is driven by his rich, unmediated interior world. Throughout the novel, his internal monologue reveals an intellectual life that directly subverts the paternalistic assumptions of the white epistemic order. James does not just possess basic human emotions; he thinks deeply and analytically, processing his daily struggles through a sophisticated engagement with Western philosophy. While hiding in the dense foliage of Jackson's Island or navigating the river, he experiences vivid, feverish dreamscapes where he engages in direct philosophical debates with canonical Western thinkers like Voltaire and John Locke (Everett 2024).

During one notable dream sequence, James confronts the spectral manifestation of John Locke, demanding that the philosopher reconcile his foundational assertions regarding human liberty with his historical justification of chattel slavery:

"You write of the social contract, Mr. Locke, and you declare that all men are endowed with natural rights to life, liberty, and estate," I said to him. "Yet, you found it logically consistent to author the Fundamental Constitutions of Carolina, which explicitly state that every freeman shall have absolute power and authority over his negro slaves. Tell me, sir, does your definition of the 'human' include the flesh that harvests your tobacco?" (Everett, 2024, p. 112).

This confrontation exposes the profound contradictions built into the heart of Eurocentric humanism. The Enlightenment thinkers formulated concepts of universal liberty while simultaneously profiting from or remaining silent on the transatlantic slave trade (Said 1993). By having an enslaved man critique these philosophers using their own tools of logic and rhetoric, Everett performs what Walter Dignolo describes as "epistemic disobedience" (Dignolo 2011). James refuses to accept the role of the primitive outsider who needs to be educated by Western

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graph TD
    A["[ Eurocentric Epistemology ]"] --> B["Formulates Universal Human Liberty"]
    B --> C["v"]
    C --> D["Excludes Enslaved Black Bodies"]
    E["[ Subaltern Intervention ]"] --> F["James Confronts Locke & Voltaire"]
    F --> G["v"]
    G --> H["Exposes Imperial Hypocrisy"]
    C <--> G
  
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The diagram illustrates the dynamics of epistemic subversion through two parallel paths. The top path begins with '[Eurocentric Epistemology]', which leads to 'Formulates Universal Human Liberty'. This process then verbalizes (v) and results in 'Excludes Enslaved Black Bodies'. The bottom path begins with '[Subaltern Intervention]', which leads to 'James Confronts Locke & Voltaire'. This process then verbalizes (v) and results in 'Exposes Imperial Hypocrisy'. A central vertical line with arrows pointing in opposite directions connects the two paths, indicating a reciprocal relationship between the two processes.

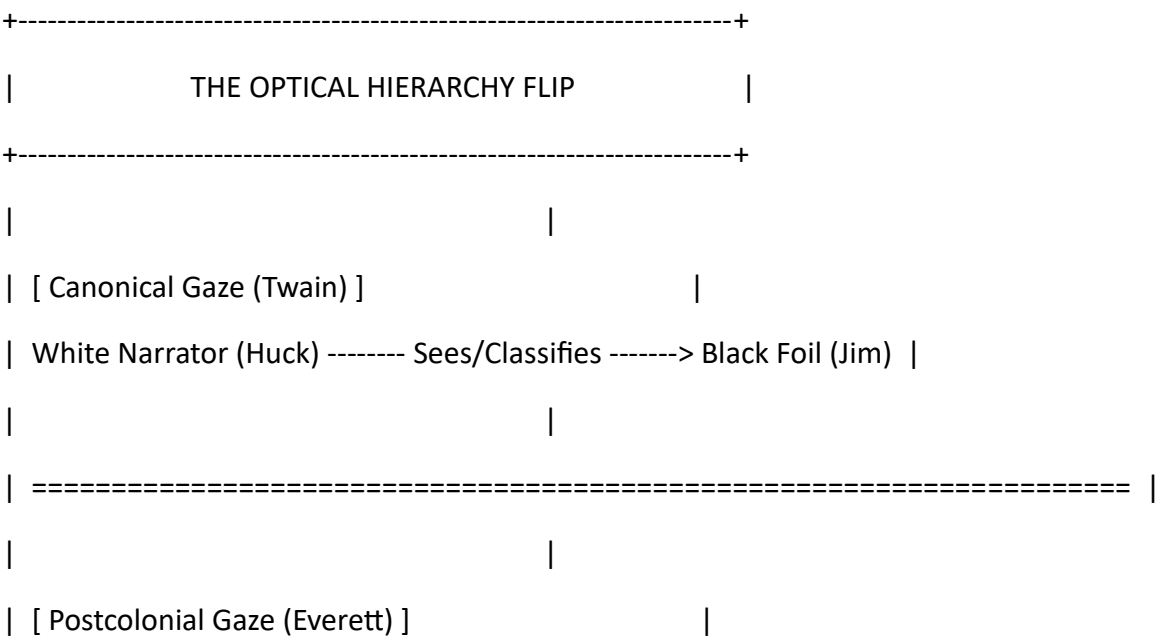
"I held the pencil between my fingers, and for the first time in my life, the world did not belong entirely to them. With every stroke of the graphite, I was carving my name into the fabric of history. They have written my body into their ledgers as property, but with this pencil, I write myself into being" (Everett, 2024, p. 145).

subaltern cannot truly speak because their voice is always translated, repackaged, and diluted by dominant institutions (Spivak 1988). Everett overcomes this limitation by having James circumvent the white narrator entirely. He does not look for a sympathetic white progressive to write his story, nor does he let his life be filtered through Huck’s naive worldview. By writing his own autobiography on the run, James seizes semantic sovereignty, transforming himself from an item listed in a master’s financial ledger into the author of his own historical destiny.

2.3 Structural Deconstruction of the Colonial Text and Counter-Hegemonic Agency

In the traditional framework of Mark Twain’s *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, the narrative gaze belongs entirely to Huck. Jim is only seen through Huck’s adolescent, racially conditioned perspective, which frames him as an object of pity, a superstitious companion, or a loyal runaway slave. Everett completely reverses this optical hierarchy, reclaiming the gaze for the subaltern. In *James*, the white characters—Huck, Tom Sawyer, Judge Thatcher, and the slave catchers—are no longer the central observers of history; instead, they become the objects of James’s critical evaluation (Everett 2024).

James observes Huck not with childlike devotion, but with a complex mix of parental affection and deep intellectual pity. He views Huck as a child who has been indoctrinated into a corrupt, logically bankrupt white society. When Huck struggles with the moral dilemma of helping a runaway slave, James recognizes that Huck's internal conflict is shaped by the absurd, contradictory laws of a slave-holding Christian civilization. By centering the gaze within James's consciousness, Everett strips the white protagonist of his narrative authority. Huck is recast as an object navigating an uneven terrain of racial privilege, while James emerges as the primary intellectual and strategic force guiding the journey.



| Sovereign Subject (James) <--- Critiques/Deconstructs -- White Object (Huck) |

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This structural deconstruction becomes clear as the journey down the Mississippi River transitions from passive physical flight into radical, active liberation. In Twain's novel, Jim's flight is a passive journey that concludes with a highly criticized sequence where Tom Sawyer treats Jim's actual captivity as an elaborate playground game, and Jim is eventually granted his freedom via a white mistress's final will. This resolution keeps Jim trapped within a cycle of white dependency and benevolence. In contrast, Everett's James undergoes a profound transformation from a runaway fugitive into a radical insurgent (Everett 2024). His journey is defined by conscious choices, tactical violence, and a determination to secure collective liberation for his family.

James's ultimate transformation occurs when he rejects the passive identity of "Jim" to fully step into his identity as "James." This psychological evolution is accompanied by concrete physical resistance. He navigates the violence of minstrel shows—where he is forced to wear literal and figurative masks—and strategically uses the chaotic breakdown of southern social order to free his family. When James kills his oppressors, it is not an act of random violence, but what Frantz Fanon describes as a cathartic, liberating force that frees the colonized subject from their internalized inferiority complex (Fanon 1963). James does not wait for a legal decree of emancipation from his masters; he liberates himself through intellectual superiority, strategic planning, and physical courage. By rewriting the climax of the river journey, Everett transforms an American story of white guilt and reconciliation into a classic postcolonial narrative of slave rebellion and self-determination.

Chapter 3: Conclusion, Recommendation and Citations

3.1 Findings

This investigation has analyzed Percival Everett's *James* (2024) through a rigorous postcolonial theoretical framework, demonstrating how the text functions as a powerful critique of Mark Twain's canonical novel *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* (1885). By utilizing the concepts of canonical counter-discourse, colonial mimicry, and subaltern agency, this study has illuminated several critical insights:

First, the investigation reveals that the linguistic dialect traditionally assigned to Black characters in canonical literature is not an organic reflection of cognitive simplicity. Instead, Everett

exposes it as an intentional, strategic performance designed to exploit the blind spots of the colonial gaze and protect the subaltern's interior life.

Second, the study shows that by shifting the narrative perspective to James, the novel dismantles the authority of the Eurocentric gaze. This shift recasts white canonical protagonists as objects of critical evaluation and challenges the universal claims of Enlightenment philosophy.

Finally, this research demonstrates that James's acquisition of literacy and his path toward armed self-defense provide a definitive answer to Spivak's query regarding subaltern speech. James achieves genuine communicative and physical sovereignty by documenting his own life and securing his own freedom.

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	SUMMARY OF RESEARCH OBJECTIVES
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	[Thesis Element] [Postcolonial Subversion in Everett's James]
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	Linguistic Strategy Code-switching functions as a protective mask
	and a tool of colonial mimicry.
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	Narrative Perspective Reclaims the Gaze, transforming canonical
	masters into objects of critical critique.
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	Epistemic Stance Confronts Western Enlightenment thinkers
	to expose structural racial hypocrisies.
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	Ultimate Agency Leverages literacy and physical resistance to
	achieve total self-determination.

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3.2 Conclusion

Percival Everett's *James* stands as a definitive intervention in contemporary historical fiction and postcolonial revisionism (Everett 2024). By breathing a sophisticated, unmediated life into an archetypal character who was historically silenced by the nineteenth-century canon, Everett exposes the structural boundaries embedded within Western literature. The novel demonstrates that the subaltern has always possessed a voice, intellectual depth, and a critical perspective on their oppression; what was lacking was a narrative framework capable of recording their reality without translating it through the white epistemic order (Spivak 1988). *James*'s journey down the Mississippi River ceases to be a simple tale of survival and becomes a powerful narrative of self-creation, intellectual resistance, and armed liberation (Everett 2024).

Ultimately, this postcolonial analysis shows that language is the primary battleground where colonial power is both enforced and overturned. By decoupling Black identity from the restricted phonetic dialect of the traditional archive, Everett redefines the relationship between language, literacy, and human agency. *James* proves that historical text can be rewritten from the margin, stripping the imperial center of its monopoly on reason, history, and truth, and offering a profound model for how contemporary literature can reclaim marginalized identities from the trauma of historical erasure (Everett 2024).

3.3 Recommendations

Based on the insights generated by this postcolonial critique of Percival Everett's *James*, the following areas are recommended for future academic research:

Comparative Decolonial Analysis: Future studies should conduct a direct comparative analysis between *James* and Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* to explore how twenty-first-century American revisions of the canon compare to twentieth-century Caribbean re-writings of British texts regarding gendered and racial subalternity.

Pedagogical Reconfiguration: Researchers should investigate the pedagogical impact of teaching Everett's *James* alongside Mark Twain's *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* in university curricula, evaluating how reading the counter-text alters student perceptions of canonical authority and systemic racism.

Minstrelsy and Performativity: A dedicated study should be conducted on the scenes involving minstrel shows in *James*, utilizing contemporary performance theory to examine how racial masks operate as spaces of capital accumulation and identity fragmentation under advanced colonial structures.

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